A beaming Modi responded, ‘I welcome the Tatas. For me, this project entails nationalistic spirit.’ The truth is, it was more than just a business deal or even ‘nationalism’ for Modi. This was a symbolic victory, the moment when he finally got what election triumphs alone could not win for him—credibility as a trustworthy administrator. His attitude during the 2002 riots had won him the hearts of the traditional BJP constituency who saw him as a leader who had stood up to ‘Islamic terrorists’ and ‘pseudo-secularists’. Being endorsed by Ratan Tata and rubbing shoulders with him gave Modi the legitimacy he secretly craved for amongst the middle class and elite well beyond Gujarat.

The Tatas, after all, are not just any other corporate. They are seen as one of India’s oldest and most respected business brands, the gold standard, in a way, of Indian business. Their Parsi roots can be traced to Gujarat. As Tata admitted, ‘We are in our home. *Amhe anhiya na chhe* (We are from here).’ Modi, never one to miss an opportunity, also reminded the audience of how a hundred years ago Jamshedji Tata had helped Gujarat by donating Rs 1000 during a famine to save cattle. It was all very cosy and convenient. Tatas desperately needed land; Modi thirsted for reinvention.

That year, Ratan Tata was chosen the CNN-IBN Indian of the Year in the business category, principally for the manner in which he had established a global presence for the Tatas. I asked him for his views on Modi. ‘He is a dynamic chief minister who has been good to us and for business in general,’ was the answer. CII 2002–03 seemed far, far away.

This was, then, the moment when Modi’s ambitions began to soar beyond Gujarat. A new self-confidence shone through, of a leader who believed his isolation was over. In this period, Modi travelled to China and Japan, countries whose economic and political systems he had long admired. This was also when Modi’s public relations machinery began working overtime to make him more ‘acceptable’ across the world. The US had denied him a visa in 2005 in the aftermath of the riots, but his NRI supporters, including the Overseas Friends of the BJP, began to vigorously lobby for him at Capitol Hill.